



**THE LAST MEN
STANDING BY:**
The traditional
allies will stand
by him, but it is
the new bunch
of friends that
could cause
problems

dictions of things to come."

He doesn't stop there. The freshly minted politician has tasted blood and he wants to cut deeper. Advani, in the rhetorical flourish of Manmohan, was the perpetrator of almost everything that was "unforgivable" in the recent history of India. He was the home minister who "slept when terrorists were knocking at the doors of our Parliament". He inspired the destruction of the Babri Masjid. He found "virtues in Mr Jinnah" but his party and his RSS mentors "disowned" him for that. "Can our nation approve the conduct of a home minister who was sleeping while Gujarat was burning? Our friends in the Left Front should ponder over the company they are forced to keep because of miscalculations by their general secretary." Pretty savage, but look at the change of tone when it comes to the Left. Still there are "friends"

out there, and they are misled by the general secretary. Manmohan is getting personal, and isn't it news as it comes from the so-called gentleman prime minister? Now that he is a full-fledged politician, he seems to realise that it is not all that easy to remain gentle, particularly when you are pitted against a war-scarred veteran like Advani and a ruthless apparatchik like Karat, who spends most of his waking hours in a Stalinist make-believe.

So the suddenly aggressive prime minister, aware of his stardom and growing popularity, has positioned himself as the Congress prime ministerial candidate of E-2009. Advani, prime minister-in-waiting, is the natural enemy, and politically, a formidable one. The attack on Advani was a calculated one, and more is likely to follow as the battle of two prime ministerial candidates enters a critical phase. In the run-up to the vote,